



“With the growing IT jobs every year in India and abroad, the industry itself is growing multifold - with the prima donna being Internet. People who want to make a career in web designing can hope to reap a rich and fulfilling harvest.”

Salil Desai

Asst. Vice President,
Arena Multimedia

Freelancers: Working as a freelancer is always a good option. Many Web designers who work with Web design firms initially go on to freelance. Running a Web design business of one's own would only happen after some good experience. A freelancer can work on individual projects and can even earn more than some salaried employees.

Qualifications

The field of Web design runs on creativity, expertise, and experience. Anyone with aesthetic sense and knowledge of Web designing tools can get absorbed in the industry. However, graduates in the fields of fine arts, visual communication, digital media, and multimedia are preferred.

One's background and educational qualifications will matter depending upon the type and size of the organisation. With small or medium enterprises, a Web design certification after graduation is usually accepted.

“As far as Web designing is concerned, degree from a particular field is not required. Being highly creative and having the ability to think out of the box are musts,” says Irshad Sheikh of Net4Nuts located in Ahmedabad, a leading Universal Resource Management service provider.

In the rarest of cases, creativity and the ability to create really good Web pages can make up for certifications and qualifications.

If you want to work with a large IT organisations that has CMM (Capability Maturity Model) standards, then the proper educational qualifications and technical certifications become necessary. CMM refers broadly to the approach of an organisation to improve its process models.

Engineering and computer science students can select programming as their major strength.

Skills

A good Web designer must have knowledge of front-end operations (the look of the Web site) as well as back-end systems (how the site would work). He must be creative enough to make use of the tools he chooses to specialise in—such as imaging tools, scripting languages, animation suites, sound creation / editing tools, etc. The front-end is undertaken by junior-level designers. After the site proto-

type is ready, senior designers test, fix bugs, and validate the design.

“We only look for a person's design ability and how engaged they are with their profession. I usually prefer people who use the Internet a lot, as only regular Net users know what sites are good and what is considered bad,” says Harish Chouhan, freelancer and owner of DreamsOnline Web Services located in Mumbai.

One can hone skills such as drawing, sketching, scribbling, and painting from an early stage—even right from the pre-college level—and take up Web design courses that complement their skill sets.

“Course material should be planned only after talking to industry leaders. Faculty should ideally be art graduates with relevant industry exposure. Just teaching candidates how to use software is not enough; the software is just a tool—creativity has to come from the candidate,” says Bedi.

Designers should be able to express technical issues in normal parlance. They should have the willingness to be updated on emerging technologies, as well as sound technical knowledge. Sketching, drawing, writing, etc. along with this would also be required for a proper blend of skills.

Training

The portfolio of the Web designer is an important aspect of his profile. Large IT corporations with CMM standards will look at projects done.

“Training is important, and grooms a fresher to industry standards. There is no specific courseware. To me, design is more like mathematics. One will need to keep working on it, hands-on, in order to master it,” says K Pradeep, project director, Niyati Technologies Pvt Ltd located in Chennai, which offers Web designing and development services.

A freshly-employed Web designer undergoes training for a period ranging from three weeks to six months. The nature and duration of the training period is dependent entirely upon prior skill sets and proficiency over scripting languages such as PHP, JSP, ASP, and others. Hands-on knowledge of tools such as Adobe Photoshop and CorelDraw (for imaging), for example, would be procured during training. Organisations are also flexible in terms of the employee undergoing education while still working.

Design Schools

National Institute of Design, Ahmedabad

Program: Graduate Diploma in Graphic Design; Post Graduate Diploma in New Media Design. www.nid.edu

Industrial Design Centre, IIT Bombay

Program: Master of Design in Visual Communication; PhD in Design in Visual Communication. www.idc.iitb.ac.in

Srishti School of Art, Design and Technology

Program: Professional Diploma in Visual Communication. www.srishtibl.org

Department of Design, IIT Guwahati

Program: Bachelor of Communication Design; Master of Communication Design; PhD in

Communication Design.

www.iitg.ernet.in/design

IIT Kanpur

Program: Master of Design in Visual Communication Design

www.iitk.ac.in/design

Symbiosis Centre of Design, Pune

Program: Bachelor of Design in Communication Design

symbiosisdesign.ac.in

Department of Visual Communication, Loyola College, Chennai

Program: Bachelor of Science in Visual Communication; MSc in Visual Communication. www.loyolacollege.edu

D J Academy of Design, Coimbatore

Program: Undergraduate Program in Communication Design. www.djad.in

Raffles Design International, Mumbai

Program: Bachelor of Arts (Hons.) in Visual Communication Design (Multimedia); Bachelor of Arts (Hons.) in Visual Communication Design (Graphic). www.raffles-design-institute.com/india

Apeejay Institute of Design

Program: Bachelor in Design; Bachelor in Multimedia; Post Graduation in Design; Master in Design. www.apeejay.edu/aid/home.htm